

Now, let us come back to the program *cob1.cob*, which can be executed with the command `cobc -x -free cob1.cob`. The option `-free` tells the compiler that the program is written in free-form style. Initial versions of COBOL had strict regulations regarding the specific rows and columns in which a particular code should be written. The option `-x` makes sure that an executable file named *cob1* is created. This executable file can be run using the command `./cob1`. Figure 1 shows the compilation and output of the program *cob1.cob*.

This program also tells us that COBOL programs are divided into different divisions. Some of these are mandatory and some others voluntary, and might be included in the program only when the need arises. Of course, COBOL does have its quirks and drawbacks. Imagine the horror of a seasoned Python programmer, who

```
File Edit View Search Terminal Help
# cobc -x -free cob1.cob
# ./cob1
Doesn't COBOL look like English?
#
```

Figure 1: Output of the program *cob1.cob*

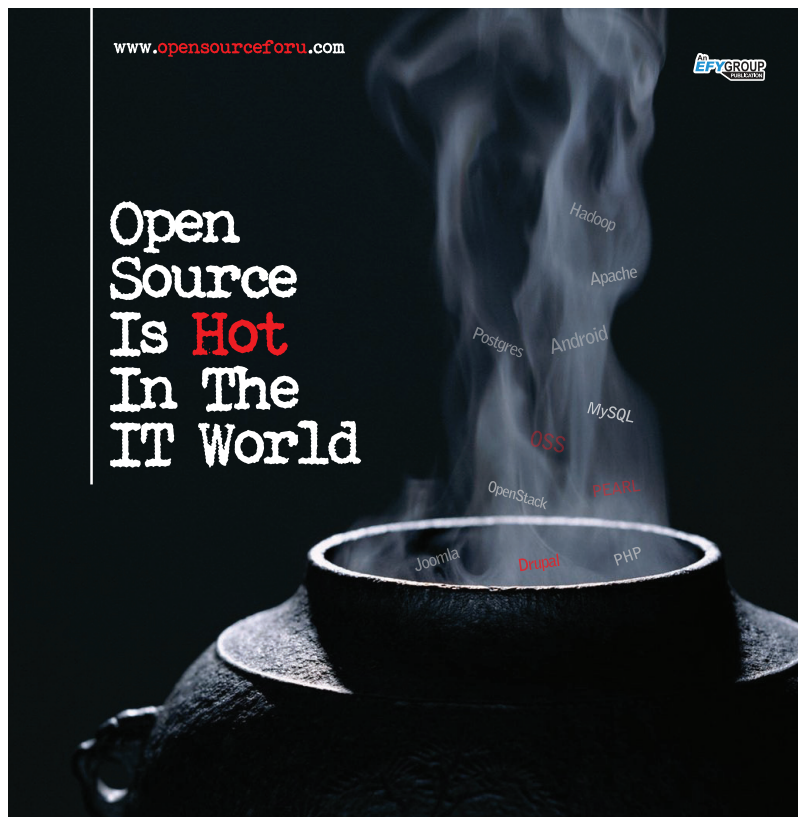
can find the sum of integers less than 100 by just using the one-liner `print sum(range(100))`, coming to know that he has to write half a page of meta-code to set up the environment even before writing a single line of actual code in COBOL. Yes! COBOL is really old and it does have problems due to its old age. Whatever the case may be, millions of lines of such code are still in existence and might be in need of maintenance. If a young programmer decides to learn

and work with COBOL, he should think of himself as a mechanic repairing vintage cars. To the best of my belief, such mechanics earn well.

In this article we have seen why COBOL is still relevant and have learned the bare minimum to begin with COBOL. Before we part ways, let me attempt predicting the future of COBOL. I believe that as long as there are COBOL applications running in mainframe computers, the language will be relevant — and that will be happening for a long time from now. In the next and final article in this series we will discuss Pascal, which is another time tested, weather-beaten programming language that is still making an impact in the programming world. **END** 🐧

By: Deepu Benson

The author is a free software enthusiast. His area of interest is theoretical computer science. The open source tools of his choice include ns-2 and ns-3. The author maintains a technical blog at www.computingforbeginners.blogspot.in.



THE COMPLETE MAGAZINE ON OPEN SOURCE



- >> To find dealers to buy copy from news-stand, visit: www.ezine.lfymag.com
- >> To subscribe, visit: pay.elyindia.com
- >> To buy an ezine edition, visit: www.magzter.com choose Open Source For You